

SAL-03 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

Role taxonomy and levelling

Ten canonical roles and a rubric that makes "senior" mean the same thing twice

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

Ten canonical project controls roles, each defined by what it is accountable for rather than what it is called, and a four-level rubric that levels a person on autonomy, scope, judgement and accountability instead of tenure or title. Together they are the classification the Institute's salary and skills survey uses, the aggregation hierarchy that governs how thin data may be combined, and a usable job architecture for any organisation that has never written one down.

— About this document

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Role taxonomy and levelling

In one paragraph. This document defines ten canonical project controls roles, each by what it is accountable for rather than what it is called, and a four-level rubric that levels a person on autonomy, scope, judgement and accountability instead of tenure or title. Together they are the classification the Institute's salary and skills survey uses, the aggregation hierarchy that governs how thin data may be combined, and a usable job architecture for any organisation that has never written one down.

Who this is for. Heads of project controls and reward specialists doing job matching or building a career structure; practitioners working out which role and level genuinely describes them; and the analysts coding survey responses.

— 1. Why titles cannot be the unit of comparison

On a single site it is normal to find a "senior planner" who owns the integrated programme for a multi-contractor scope, and a "planning manager" who maintains one contractor's schedule and reports it upward. Both titles are honest inside their own organisations. Compared with each other, they are noise.

Titles inflate over time, deflate under headcount pressure, absorb local convention, and are frequently used as a substitute for pay. They are also the only classification most market data uses — the single largest reason published pay figures for this profession are unreliable. The cell labelled "planner" contains four different jobs.

The alternative is not complicated. Classify on two axes that describe the work rather than the label: **what the person is accountable for** (the role) and **how much judgement and scope they carry** (the level). A cost engineer at practitioner level in a contractor organisation is a recognisable, comparable thing in Perth, Riyadh and Rotterdam. "Senior cost engineer" is not.

— 2. How to use this taxonomy

In the survey. Question Q07 in [SAL-02](#) asks for the role by what the respondent spends most of their time doing; Q09 asks for the level using the behavioural descriptors in §4 below; Q06 captures the employer's title as free text and is never used as the classification variable. Coding rules are in §8.

In an organisation. The ten roles and four levels are a job architecture you may adopt directly. They are deliberately fewer than most internal structures, because a taxonomy with forty roles cannot be applied consistently by the twelve people who have to apply it.

What this is not. Not a pay structure, and it carries no pay implication of any kind. Not a statement that every organisation needs all ten roles — most need three or four. And not a competency framework: competence is defined in the Institute's competency series, which this document maps to rather than duplicates (see §7).

[CONFIRM: whether this taxonomy is ratified by the Standards Committee as the Institute's published job architecture, or published as a research instrument only]

— 3. The ten canonical roles

Each definition states the role's purpose, what it is accountable for, the artefacts it owns, the decision it is trusted with, and the boundary that most often gets blurred. The Body of Knowledge domains are given by number, per [docs/bok/](#).

3.1 Planner / scheduler

Purpose. To construct and maintain the model of how the work will be sequenced in time, and to tell the truth about where it currently is against that model.

Accountable for. Schedule structure and logic; the baseline and its integrity; progress capture and status; critical path and float analysis; time impact of change. **Owns.** The programme or schedule file, the schedule basis and assumptions document, the progress report, the schedule narrative. **Trusted to decide.** How the work is logically represented, and what the schedule says about completion — including when that is unwelcome. **Boundary.** A planner is not a progress clerk. Where the role is only updating percentages supplied by others, that is a foundation-level activity within the role, not the role itself. **BoK domains.** 10 (scheduling), 8 (lifecycle), 6 (earned value forecasting), 12 (risk).

3.2 Cost engineer

Purpose. To connect scope, quantity and money — building the cost model and keeping it consistent with what is actually being built.

Accountable for. The cost breakdown structure and its alignment to the work breakdown structure; budgets and commitments at control-account level; unit rates and quantities; cost impact of change; the data behind the forecast. **Owns.** The cost model, the control-account budget, the variance analysis, the cost basis of estimate at completion (EAC). **Trusted to decide.** How cost is structured and how a variance is explained. **Boundary.** The cost engineer builds and analyses; the cost controller runs the periodic control cycle. In smaller teams one person does both, and in the survey they pick the larger half of their time. **BoK domains.** 5 (cost management), 3 (budgeting and forecasting), 6 (EVM/EAC), 1 (accounting foundations).

3.3 Cost controller

Purpose. To operate the monthly control cycle so that reported cost is complete, cut off correctly and reconciled to the accounts.

Accountable for. Commitment and expenditure capture; accruals and cut-off; reconciliation between the project ledger and the finance system; invoice and payment status; the integrity of the reported actuals. **Owns.** The cost report, the accrual schedule, the reconciliation, the cost ledger interface. **Trusted to decide.** What is accrued, what is deferred, and when the books close. **Boundary.** Not project accounting, and not management accounting. The cost controller is accountable for the project's numbers being right and reconcilable, not for the entity's financial statements. **BoK domains.** 5, 4 (performance management and management reporting), 11 (business process cycles), 2 (financial reporting).

3.4 Estimator

Purpose. To produce a defensible view of what work will cost before it is done, with the uncertainty stated.

Accountable for. Estimate structure, methodology and class; quantity take-off and pricing basis; benchmark and norm selection; allowances and the estimate's uncertainty range; the basis of estimate. **Owns.** The estimate, the basis of estimate, the estimate reconciliation between revisions. **Trusted to decide.** Method and class of estimate, and what is included in an allowance rather than a contingency. **Boundary.** The estimator sets the number the project starts with; the cost engineer controls it thereafter. Where they are the same person the roles must still be distinguished, because estimating your own control baseline is a governance weakness worth knowing about. **BoK domains.** 3, 5, 7 (contracts and commercial).

3.5 Risk analyst

Purpose. To make uncertainty explicit and quantified, so that decisions account for it rather than discovering it.

Accountable for. Risk identification and register quality; qualitative assessment discipline; quantitative cost and schedule risk analysis; contingency derivation and drawdown analysis; the link between risk and the forecast. **Owns.** The risk register, the quantitative schedule risk analysis (QSRA) model and its inputs, the contingency basis. **Trusted to decide.** How uncertainty is modelled, and what the analysis says about confidence in a target date or cost. **Boundary.** Not the risk owner. The analyst runs the process and the arithmetic; the accountable manager owns the risk and the response. **BoK domains.** 12 (risk), 10, 6.

3.6 Change / commercial controller

Purpose. To control the boundary between what was agreed and what is now being done, in both directions.

Accountable for. Change identification, valuation and authorisation; variation and instruction records; entitlement and notice discipline; claim and extension-of-time (EOT) substantiation; the commercial audit trail. **Owns.** The change register, the variation file, the claim narrative and its supporting records. **Trusted to decide.** Whether something is a change, and what evidence is required before it is valued. **Boundary.** Sits between project controls and the commercial or quantity surveying function, and in some organisations reports into the latter. The role is included here because the work is controls work wherever it reports. **BoK domains.** 7, 11, 5.

3.7 Reporting and data analyst

Purpose. To turn controls data into something a decision-maker can act on, without distorting it in transit.

Accountable for. Data model and data quality across controls systems; the reporting pipeline; dashboards and their definitions; automation of recurring reporting; increasingly, the responsible application of analytical and AI tooling to controls data. **Owns.** The data model, the dashboard definitions, the reporting calendar, the automation scripts. **Trusted to decide.** How a metric is defined and computed, and what a visualisation is allowed to imply. **Boundary.** Not a business-intelligence developer who happens to sit near a project: the role requires knowing what an earned-

value number means before displaying it. Distinguishing the two is one of the things this taxonomy exists to make possible. **BoK domains.** 4, 13 (AI for project controls), 6.

3.8 Project controls lead

Purpose. To integrate cost, schedule, risk and change on a project into one coherent account of status and forecast.

Accountable for. Integration across the controls disciplines; the integrity of the reported position; the controls calendar and cycle; the forecast the project reports; the quality of what the team produces. **Owns.** The project controls execution plan, the integrated report, the forecast position. **Trusted to decide.** What the project reports, and when a number is not yet fit to report. **Boundary.** A lead is defined by integration, not by headcount. A lead with no direct reports is normal; a "senior planner" who integrates cost, schedule and risk into a single reported position is functioning as a lead and is coded as one. **BoK domains.** 4, 5, 6, 10.

3.9 Project controls manager

Purpose. To run the controls function for a project, programme or business unit — its people, its methods and its standards.

Accountable for. The controls team and its capability; method, process and tooling; assurance over project reporting; interface with finance, commercial and delivery leadership; recruitment and development. **Owns.** The functional standard and procedures, the assurance regime, the resourcing plan. **Trusted to decide.** How controls is done here, and whether a project's reported position is credible enough to leave the function. **Boundary.** Distinguished from the lead by accountability for how the work is done across more than one delivery vehicle, rather than for one vehicle's numbers. **BoK domains.** 4, 8, 12, 5.

3.10 Head of project controls

Purpose. To own the controls capability of the organisation: its standard, its systems, its people pipeline and its voice at executive level.

Accountable for. The functional strategy and standard; systems and data architecture for controls; capability development and succession; governance and assurance across the portfolio; representing the integrity of reported performance to the board or client at the point where it is uncomfortable. **Owns.** The functional standard, the systems roadmap, the capability plan, the assurance framework. **Trusted to decide.** What the organisation's controls standard is, and what it will not report. **Boundary.** Titles vary widely at this level — director, head of function, discipline lead, chief. Classify on organisational scope, not on the word. **BoK domains.** 8, 4, 13.

A note on roles not listed. Document control, project accounting, quantity surveying, contract administration and project management proper are adjacent professions with their own structures. They are out of scope here rather than junior versions of anything above; the survey routes respondents in those roles out at screening.

— 4. The levelling rubric

Four levels, matching the Institute's competency levels so the survey and the competency framework can be read together: **foundation · practitioner · professional · leader (CMP-02).**

Two vocabulary warnings, both of which cause real confusion. First, professional here is a level on a competency scale — it is not the same idea as the level at which the Institute's credentials sit, which is Leader. Second, senior is not a level in this rubric and never will be, because it is the word employers use to mean whatever they need it to mean.

Levelling runs on six dimensions.

Dimension	Foundation	Practitioner	Professional	Leader
Autonomy	Works to instruction on defined tasks; output is checked	Works to an objective; chooses method within an established framework	Sets the approach for a scope and is relied on without checking	Sets the framework others work within
Scope owned	Part of a discipline on part of a project	A discipline on a project, or part of one on a large project	An integrated scope, a large or complex project, or a discipline across several	A function, a portfolio, or an organisational capability
Judgement under ambiguity	Escalates when data is missing or contradictory	Resolves routine ambiguity; escalates the novel	Makes and defends a call where the data does not settle it	Decides where reasonable experts disagree, and carries the consequence
Accountability for the number	Accurate execution of a defined calculation	The number for their scope, and its explanation	The reported position, including what it implies	The organisation's reported position and its integrity
Influence	Within the immediate team	Across the project team; explains to non-specialists	Persuades delivery and commercial leadership, including against preference	Board, client and external; sets expectations others must meet
Development of others and of method	Learning the method	Supports others; applies method as given	Improves method; coaches; reviews others' work	Owens the method; builds the capability and the pipeline

The signature test. Beyond the table, each level has work that only it does. Foundation produces accurate data. Practitioner produces a defensible answer. Professional produces a defensible answer that survives contact with someone who does not want to hear it. Leader decides what the organisation will stand behind, and is the person who says the number is not ready.

— 5. Applying the rubric

Nobody sits cleanly at one level on all six dimensions. The decision rule:

1. Score each of the six dimensions independently.
2. The assigned level is the one with the most dimensions. Ties are broken by **accountability for the number**, then by **autonomy** — the two that most reliably distinguish real from nominal seniority.
3. **The scope ceiling.** A person cannot be levelled above the scope they actually own. Someone with leader-level influence and practitioner-level scope is levelled on the scope. This rule prevents the most common inflation, which is levelling on visibility.
4. **Tenure is not a dimension.** Long service at one level is long service at one level.

5. **Headcount is not a dimension.** It appears nowhere in the table, deliberately: technical leadership without direct reports is real leadership in this discipline.

Where a survey respondent's self-assessment at Q09 conflicts with their answers on scope (Q12), reporting line (Q10) and role, the conflict is recorded but the self-assessment stands. Overriding it would replace a stated measurement with an analyst's inference, and inference cannot be disclosed to a reader in the way a rule can.

— 6. Aggregation hierarchy

[SAL-01](#) §6 rule 5 permits combining thin cells only along a hierarchy declared in advance. This is that hierarchy, and it may not be varied for a particular table.

Roles combine upward into four groups, and no further:

Group	Roles
Cost and commercial	Cost engineer · Cost controller · Estimator · Change / commercial controller
Planning and risk	Planner / scheduler · Risk analyst
Data and reporting	Reporting and data analyst
Controls leadership	Project controls lead · Project controls manager · Head of project controls

Levels combine only as adjacent pairs: foundation with practitioner, professional with leader. A combination spanning all four is never published, because a figure covering every level of a profession describes nobody in it.

Geography combines country into sub-region into region, along a stated list published with the report. Countries are never combined ad hoc to reach a threshold.

Every combined cell is labelled as combined, in the cell and not only in a footnote.

— 7. Mapping to the competency framework

The Institute's competency series ([CMP-01](#) to [CMP-10](#)) defines what competence looks like; this taxonomy defines what jobs exist and how they are levelled. The two meet at the level labels, which are shared, and at the competency sets.

For the project controls credential PCL-AI, the platform's seeded set of fourteen competencies maps to the roles as follows. Each role's primary competencies are those the role is accountable for; every role touches more.

Role	Primary PCL-AI competencies
Planner / scheduler	Planning and scheduling · Performance measurement · Project risk
Cost engineer	Cost management · Forecasting and EAC · Earned value management
Cost controller	Cost management · Performance measurement · Project controls governance
Estimator	Cost management · Forecasting and EAC
Risk analyst	Project risk · Predictive analytics · Forecasting and EAC
Change / commercial controller	Commercial and contract controls · Cost management
Reporting and data analyst	Digital reporting · Automation · AI-enabled project controls · Predictive analytics
Project controls lead	Performance measurement · Earned value management · Forecasting and EAC · Project controls governance
Project controls manager	Project controls governance · Human validation · Responsible AI
Head of project controls	Project controls governance · Responsible AI · Human validation

Two competencies — **responsible AI** and **human validation** — appear as primary only at manager and head level, and that placement is a position, not an oversight. Every role uses AI-assisted tooling; accountability for whether its output is fit to rely on escalates with the level that carries accountability for the reported number. This is the Institute's standing position — AI proposes; the professional disposes — expressed as a levelling consequence.

[CONFIRM: whether the role-to-competency mapping above is reviewed and endorsed by the Standards Committee before publication, or presented as an editorial mapping]

[CONFIRM: reconciliation of these role definitions with the task statements produced by the forthcoming PCL-AI job-task analysis, once that study has been run]

— 8. Coding rules for free-text titles

For analysts coding Q06 where Q07 was answered **Other**, or where a response is inconsistent.

1. Code from the accountability described, never from the title string alone.
2. Where a title contains two roles ("planning and cost engineer"), code the primary role from Q07 and record the second at Q08. Do not create hybrid categories.
3. Ignore all seniority words when assigning the role — senior, principal, lead, chief, junior, graduate, assistant, associate. They inform nothing about the role and are handled by the level, which is measured separately.
4. Treat "lead" in a title as evidence of the lead role only where the described accountability is integration across disciplines. Otherwise it is a level signal, not a role signal, and even then it is not decisive.
5. Where an employer's title has no relationship to the described work, code the work and flag the record. Flagged records are counted and the count is published.
6. Where a role genuinely falls outside the ten, code it **OTHER** with the verbatim description retained. **OTHER** is reported as a count and never distributed across the ten to tidy the table.

7. Double-code a sample of records independently and report the agreement, under the same rules the skills codebook uses ([SAL-04 §5](#)).

— 9. How this goes wrong

Levelling on title after all. The rubric is adopted, then someone maps titles to levels once and applies the mapping thereafter. Within two cycles the data is title data with a rubric-shaped label on it.

Levelling on tenure. Fifteen years in the same role becomes "professional" because it feels disrespectful not to. The scope ceiling in §5 exists for this moment.

Headcount as the leadership test. A technically formidable practitioner who owns the method for a portfolio is levelled below a manager of three, because one has reports and the other does not. In this discipline that is usually the wrong way round.

The everything role. In a small organisation one person is planner, cost engineer, risk analyst and lead. Coding them into all four inflates every cell; coding them into the largest half of their time, with the second recorded, is the only defensible option and must be applied consistently.

Roles invented to fit an internal structure. An organisation adopts the taxonomy and adds four local roles. Legitimate internally, fatal to comparison — local roles must resolve back to one of the ten before any figure is compared with anyone else's.

Assuming the taxonomy is a pay ladder. The ten roles are not ordered by value and the four levels carry no pay implication. The honest use is job matching, after which pay is a separate question with its own evidence.

— 10. Checklist — matching a job to this taxonomy

- [] Read the job's accountabilities, not its title
 - [] Identify what artefact the job owns and what decision it is trusted with
 - [] Choose the role by where most of the time goes; record a second role if the split is genuine
 - [] Score all six levelling dimensions independently before deciding the level
 - [] Apply the scope ceiling: no level above the scope actually owned
 - [] Check the tie-breakers — accountability for the number, then autonomy
 - [] Confirm tenure and headcount played no part in the decision
 - [] Record any conflict between the self-assessed level and the scope answers
 - [] Where the role does not fit, code it as other and keep the description — do not force it
 - [] Re-read the resulting classification and ask whether two people classified identically would recognise each other's jobs
-

— Related

- [SAL-02 – The survey instrument](#) — the questions this taxonomy classifies, and the definitions linked from them

- [SAL-04 – The skills demand taxonomy](#) — the skills vocabulary applied across these roles
- [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — where role and level become reporting dimensions
- [CMP-01 – The PCI competency framework – overview](#) — what competence means, as distinct from what a job is
- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — the shared level labels and the evidence each requires
- [CAR-01 – The project controls career roadmap](#) — how a career moves through these roles and levels

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited. The competency names in §7 are the Institute's own seeded competency set for PCL-AI as recorded in [00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §7; the level labels are those used by the competency series and the framework's front-matter schema. Body of Knowledge domain numbers refer to the thirteen domains in [docs/bok/](#). The role definitions are the Institute's editorial synthesis of how the work is organised across sectors; they are not drawn from, and do not reproduce, any other body's job architecture.

— Status and version

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